

CHAPTER TWO

Ancient Bengal

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(a) Hindu-Buddhist Dynasties

The reconstruction of the history of Bengal in the pre-Muslim period is difficult due to paucity of sources. The difficulty is felt more acutely for the earlier period from the earliest time to the 4th century A.D., when Bengal came under the Imperial Guptas. From then onwards we get written records in the form of epigraphs and literature which contain information on the history of the region of Bengal. For the earlier period we have to depend on very scanty references in the Vedic, Epic and Puranic literature as well as on the available archaeological evidence.

It must be made clear at the very outset that by the region of Bengal we include the territories of present-day Bangladesh and the province of West Bengal of India. It must be realised that the history of the region in the ancient period had an unitary trend and it is difficult to bring out the history of present day Bangladesh separately. So, for the ancient period, we would consider the history of the whole region of Bengal as a whole.

Background

In the earliest period Bengal was known to be inhabited by different groups of people, whose names came to be associated with the area inhabited by them. Thus the ancient *janapadas* of Vanga, Pundra, Radha and Gauda came to be recognised as inhabited by non-Aryan ethnic groups bearing those names. Pundra roughly comprised the territories of northern Bangladesh and parts of north Bengal of the Indian province of West Bengal, whereas Gauda denoted parts of mid-West Bengal. Radha included the southern part of present West Bengal. Vanga denoted the major portion of present Bangladesh— its southern and south-eastern districts. Samatata was an important *janapada* in the

trans-Meghna region of Bangladesh in its south-eastern part (Comilla – Noakhali area). The name of this *janapada* was purely descriptive and had no ethnic connection. The Chittagong area with its adjacent areas was known by the name of Harikela. The existence of these *janapadas* is known from the later Vedic literature, as areas inhabited by non-Aryan people.

Aryan Influence in ancient India came to be felt in the north-western parts in the middle of the second millennium B.C. and it took a long time for the Aryans to reach the eastern limits of the subcontinent. Thus the people of Bengal felt the tide of *Aryanisation* quite late. From about 5th century B.C. it pushed into Bengal from the western side and it took about one thousand years to Aryanise the whole of Bengal. By the time Aryan influence reached Bengal, it had become feeble during its long march through the entire area of northern India. Thus the pre-Aryan elements in the culture of the people of Bengal got time to be rooted deeply and even under Aryan influence, which was feeble, they retained many elements in their life and culture which are non-Aryan and definitely pre-Aryan.

Stone tools provide the earliest evidence of human settlements. Pre-historic stone implements have been discovered in various parts of West Bengal in the districts of Midnapur, Bankura and Burdwan. But it is difficult to determine, even approximately, the time when people using them first settled in Bengal. It might have taken place ten thousand years (or even more) ago. The original settlers were the non-Aryan ethnic groups – Nishadās or Austric or Austro-Asiatics – who are now represented by the primitive peoples known as Kola, Bhil, Santal, Sabara, Pulinda etc. At a subsequent age, peoples of two other ethnic stocks whose language was Dravidian and Tibeto-Burman settled in Bengal.

The archaeological discoveries during the 1960s have furnished evidence of a comparatively much higher degree of civilisation in certain parts of Bengal even at such a remote period as the beginning of the first millennium B.C., perhaps even earlier. The discoveries at ‘Pandu Rajar Dhibi’ in the valley of the Ajay river (near Bolpur) in the Burdwan district and in several other sites on the Ajay, Kunar and Kopai rivers have thrown fresh light on Bengal’s pre-history. ‘Pandu Rajar Dhibi’ represents the ruins of a trading township, which carried on trade not only with the interior regions of India, but also with the countries of the Mediterranean world. It is evident from the Vedic literature that the Aryans regarded the peoples whom they met in Bengal as barbarians. But the evidence of the higher material culture that have come to light in West Bengal proves beyond any doubt the invalidity of the Aryan idea. At the same time it must be said that Aryan settlements, which happened gradually over a long period of time, profoundly affected its culture and the process of gradual Aryanisation forms the chief point of interest in the subsequent history of the region. The history of ancient Bengal from the 4th century A.D. onwards, which appears to us in more or less clear light, is the history of Aryan domination, both from the political and cultural points of view.

Greek and Latin sources (3rd century B.C. - 1st century A.D.) refer to an eastern Indian nation/state called '*Gangaridae* (Greek)/'*Gangaridai*' (Latin) which was very strong militarily. Scholars have located '*Gangaridai*' in parts of southern and south-eastern Bengal, adjacent to the mouths of the Ganges (Bhagirathi and Padma).

An inscription written in the Brahmi script found in excavation in the site of the old *Pundranagar*, now represented by the ruins at Mahasthana in Bogra district, bears testimony to Maurya rule (3rd century B.C.) in parts of Bengal. This inscription, the earliest epigraphic record in Bangladesh, establishes the identification of ancient Pundranagar with modern *Mahasthangarh* of Bogra district. Pundranagar is thus the earliest urban settlement in Bangladesh. Archaeological excavations prove the existence of this urban administrative and cultural centre throughout the ancient period up to the 12th century A.D. The fragmentary Brahmi inscription refers to relief measures, such as distribution of paddy and money, to be undertaken by the administration during the time of calamities caused by nature and the collection of the distributed amount of paddy and money when good days return. Thus it proves that famines and natural calamities are very old companions of the people in this part of the world. The idea of returning the relief speaks of the mutual respect between the administration and the people.

The *Arthashastra* of Kautiliya (3rd century B.C.) refers to fine cotton fabric of Vanga (south-eastern Bengal) as an important item of her trade throughout India. The Greek and Latin writers (more or less of the same period) also mention it. Thus it may be emphasized that the tradition of weaving fine cotton cloth goes back to a very early period. It was this item of southeastern Bengal, which in the 16th and 17th centuries A.D. earned worldwide fame as the 'Muslin' of Bengal, and specifically of Dhaka. It may also be mentioned here that the making of terracotta plaques is also a very old art tradition in Bengal. Terracotta plaques have been found in the excavations at *Pandu Rajar Dhibi*, which prove the antiquity of this art in Bengal.

Gupta Rule

The history of Bengal from the fall of the Mauryas (2nd century B.C.) to the rise of the Guptas (4th century A.D.) is obscure. The discovery of some beautiful terracotta figurines at *Mahasthana*, *Tamralipti* and *Chandraketugarh*, datable in the 2nd and 1st centuries B.C., proves that Bengal continued to flourish in the Sunga and Kushana periods. It appears from the accounts of *The Periplus of the Erythrean Sea* and Ptolemy that in the first two centuries of the Christian era the whole of deltaic Bengal was organised into a powerful kingdom with its capital at Gange, a great market town on the banks of the Ganges. We have evidence of widespread trade between Bengal and China as well as other countries. The *Milinda-Panho* mentions Vanga in a list of maritime countries where ships congregated for the purpose of trade.

It is likely that on the eve of Gupta expansion under Samudragupta (4th century A.D.) Bengal remained divided into independent states. By about the middle of the 4th century A.D. most independent states came under Samudragupta's rule. Samatata (the trans-Meghna region comprising Comilla-Noakhali area) was outside his empire, but was reduced to the status of a tributary state. Samudragupta's son and successor, Chandragupta II consolidated their possessions in the east and had to wage wars against the Vangas. Gupta suzerainty over Samatata might have come at a later stage and by the end of the 6th century AD this area appears to have been ruled by a king with his name ending with Gupta (Vainyugupta). Several copper-plates of 5th century Gupta emperors (Kumaragupta – Budhagupta) found in northern Bengal prove the existence of a well-established Gupta rule in that area. They also testify to the existence of a well-structured local administration in which the representatives of the local people had the opportunity of playing an important part. It goes to the credit of the Gupta emperors that they established an administration in Bengal in which the participation of the local people was ensured. The set-up of the local administration, as evidenced by the Gupta copperplates, is undoubtedly the earliest instance of local self-government in Bengal and its significance cannot be overestimated.

Under Gupta rule Bengal was an important province. The period of the Imperial Guptas is generally considered to be the golden age of Indian history. During this period India was under a strong benevolent central government, which brought peace, wealth and prosperity for a considerable time. Bengal enjoyed the benefit of being a part of the All-Indian empire, in which there prevailed efficient administration and political stability. This period is remarkable for its trade and commerce, in which Bengal had her due share. *Fa-hsien*, the Chinese visitor, states that in the east Tamralipti (modern Tamruk in Midnapur district of West Bengal) was the great emporium of trade. The discovery of large number of Gupta coins and imitation Gupta coins in Bengal prove the economic prosperity of the region under the Guptas.

The period is also remarkable for religious toleration. The imperial Gupta monarchs embraced Brahmanism and styled themselves *Paramabhagavatas* or *Paramadaivatas*, but they also patronised Buddhism and Jainism. The people of the period enjoyed an environment of religious toleration and coexistence of religious beliefs. The artistic excellence of the Gupta age is well known and it influenced the artistic tradition of Bengal. The Gupta School inspired the Bengal school of sculptural art.

Sasanka

The break up of the Gupta empire, the invasions of the Hunas and the sudden entry and exit of Yasodharman on the political stage of northern India gave great shocks to eastern India. In the first half of the sixth century A.D. south and east

Bengal shook off the suzerainty of the Guptas and attained importance as an independent kingdom under local rulers – the kingdom of Vanga. In the central part of northern India the Maukharis rose to prominence and the later Guptas held sway over Bihar, western and northern Bengal. There was a long drawn out struggle between the Maukharis and the later Guptas for the possession of Magadha (southern Bihar) and parts of western and northern Bengal.

Towards the close of the sixth century A.D. the kingdom of Gauda emerged in parts of western and northern Bengal under the later Guptas. But by the beginning of the seventh century Gauda emerged as an independent kingdom under Sasanka and Magadha formed a part of his dominions. There is no doubt that Sasanka occupies an important place in the history of Bengal. He is the first known king of Bengal to extend his suzerainty over territories far beyond the geographical boundaries of that province. He attempted at establishing a north Indian empire and held his own as well as the independence of the Gauda empire against a very powerful adversary, Harshavardhana, who may be said to have revived the Imperial tradition of a northern Indian empire by founding a vast empire embracing practically the whole of northern India and parts of southern India. It was no mean achievement on the part of Sasanka to have preserved his own entity against such a powerful adversary. Even for a king of Bengal it was a great show of strength to have ventured into northern Indian politics.

Of the early life of Sasanka and the circumstances in which he occupied the throne of Gauda we do not have any definite evidence. But it seems very clear that he ruled over a vast territory. He made himself master of western and northern Bengal and conquered territory as far as the Chilka Lake in Orissa. Parts of Bihar (Magadha) were within his empire. He ventured as far as Kanauj in the central part of northern India by taking advantage of the contemporary political situation and in alliance with Devagupta, the ruler of Malwa in western India. His capital, *Karnasuvarna*, has been identified with Rangamati, six miles southwest of Baharampur in the Murshidabad district of Indian West Bengal.

Sasanka was a staunch Shaivite (follower of Shiva) and *Hsuen Tsang*, the Chinese Buddhist pilgrim, depicts him as a strong anti-Buddhist and many acts of vandalism and enmity against Buddhists are ascribed to him. Whether all these accusations made by the contemporary Buddhist author, who was a great friend of Sasanka's adversary Harshavardhana, are correct or not we are not certain. However, political reasons rather than religious enmity may have prompted the persecution of Buddhists in certain areas. Almost all that we know about this great king of Gauda comes from hostile sources. If he had a biographer like Banabhatta or a foreigner friend like Hsuen Tsang, his character might have been painted as attractively as that of Harshavardhana. But there can hardly be a dispute in regarding him the first important king of Bengal who could launch Bengal for the first time in her history on aggressive endeavors towards establishing supremacy over northern India. In this sense he was the forerunner

of the aggressive northern Indian policy of the later day Pala rulers like Dharmapala and Devapala.

Matsyanyayam

The death of Sasanka was followed by a period of anarchy and lawlessness. For more than a century, roughly from 650 to 750 A.D., the history of Gauda is obscure in the extreme. The period was marked by political chaos and confusion caused by the death of Harshavardhana (646 or 647 A.D.), the usurpation of his kingdom by his ministers, and the adventures of the Chinese envoy *Wang-hiuen-tse*. It was followed by the invasions of the powerful king of Tibet, *Srong-tsan-Gampo*. In the second half of the seventh century A.D. Bengal saw the emergence of two new lines of kings: the later Guptas in Gauda and Magadha (western Bengal and southern Bihar) and the Khadgas in Vanga and Samatata (southern and south-eastern Bengal). Neither of these dynasties, however, appears to have succeeded in establishing a united and strong rule in Bengal.

In the first half of the 8th century A.D., Bengal was overwhelmed by repeated foreign invasions, the most notable of which was the invasion of Yasovarman of Kanauj (725-752 A.D.). The glories of Yasovarman were soon eclipsed by Lalitaditya of Kashmir. The Kashmiri historian Kalhana refers to five Gauda kings defeated by Lalitaditya and this clearly indicates a state of political disintegration in Gauda, which became a field of struggle for the local chiefs who assumed independence in the absence of any central authority. The successive foreign invasions destroyed the political equilibrium and hastened the process of disintegration.

In the century following the death of Sasanka, Bengal saw very little of stable government and the whole country was torn by internal strife and disturbed by invasions from outside. The condition of Bengal towards the middle of the 8th century A.D., before the rise of Gopala, found mention in one of the Pala records (Khalimpur copperplate) as a state of *matsyanyayam*. *Taranatha*, the Tibetan monk who wrote his *History of Buddhism in India* in 1608 A.D., confirms this and writes: "... every Ksatriya, Grandee, Brahman and merchant was a king in his own house (or in the neighbourhood) but there was no king ruling over the country." Gopala, the founder of the dynasty, emerged as the ruler out of this chaos, and as mentioned in the Pala copperplate, put an end to the state of lawlessness (*matsyanyayam*).

The Sanskrit term *matsyanyayam* has special significance. The *Kautiliya Arthasastra* explains the term as follows: when the law of punishment is kept in abeyance, it gives rise to such disorder as is implied in the proverb of fishes, i.e., the larger fish swallows a small one, for in the absence of law-enforcing authority, the strong will swallow the weak. The contemporary Pala record uses this significant term to describe the prevailing political situation in Bengal. It was a

situation of complete lawlessness arising out of the absence of a strong ruling power capable of enforcing law and order. Gopala emerged to the helm of affairs in Bengal and succeeded in putting an end to the state of *matsyanyayam*.

The process of Gopala's rise to power has been a matter of controversy among historians. Some have argued that the people elected Gopala as their king and one has gone so far as to say, "About the middle of the eighth century A.D. a heroic and laudable effort was made to remedy the miserable state of things. The people at last realised that all their troubles were due to the absence of a strong central authority and this could be set up only by voluntary surrender of powers to one popular leader by the numerous chiefs exercising sovereignty in different parts of the country.... It is not every age, it is not every nation, that can show such a noble example of subordinating private interests to public welfare".

Without going into the details of the controversy it may be said that Gopala came to occupy the throne at a time when there was chaos and confusion and he must have had the support of a group of influential people or leaders and his success in putting an end to the state of *matsyanyayam* may have earned popular support for him. It is claimed in the Pala records that Gopala "attained everlasting peace after having overcome the power of those who were acting according to their own desires", or, in other words, those who had created the situation of *matsyanyayam* in Bengal.

The Pala Dynasty

The dynasty founded by Gopala in mid-8th century A.D., ruled Bengal for about four hundred years with various vicissitudes. During this long period of eighteen generations of kings we notice ups and downs in the fortunes of the dynasty. But there can hardly be any doubt regarding the fact that the rule of the Palas formed a glorious chapter in the history of ancient Bengal. The history of the long line of Pala rulers can be viewed under different phases: (i) *Period of Ascendancy* under Dharmapala (c.781 – 821 A.D.) and Devapala (c.821 – 861 A.D.); followed by a (ii) *Period of Stagnation* (c.861 – 995 A.D.) to be rejuvenated by Mahipala I (c.995 – 1043 A.D.), who is considered to be the second founder of the dynasty; and the last phase (iii) *Period of Decline and Disintegration*, which was halted briefly by the vigorous rule of Ramapala (c.1082 – 1124 A.D.). But the Pala empire did not last long after him and the final collapse came with the rise of the Senas in the third quarter of the 12th century A.D.

The period of ascendancy saw the vigorous rule of Dharmapala and Devapala. In this period the Palas were powerful enough to challenge the mastery of northern India. In their bid for this mastery they were involved in a tripartite struggle with the Gurjara Pratiharas of western India and the Rashtrakutas of southern India. When Bengal saw the rise of the Palas, the *Rashtrakutas* wrested power from the Chalukyas in the Deccan, and the Gurjara Pratiharas consolidated their power in Malwa and Rajasthan. In northern India there was a vacuum

after it was swept over by Yasovarman and Lalitaditya. So during the subsequent two generations northern India with its traditional central seat at Kanauj felt a rush on the part of these three powers to fill up this vacuum.

During Dharmapala's reign there were two phases of this tripartite struggle. Though he suffered reverses in the first phase of this struggle, he achieved some success in the interval between the first and the second phase. He succeeded in advancing his influence up to Kanauj, where he put his protege Chakrayudha to rule for some time. The Pala empire extended beyond the boundaries of Bengal and Bihar as far as Kanauj. He may have pushed his empire in other directions as well, but we are not sure about the amount of success. In the second phase of the tripartite struggle Dharmapala tasted reverses. But there is very little doubt that he succeeded in maintaining his hold outside Bengal and Bihar. Dharmapala's name stands out in the annals of the Pala dynasty as a great conqueror under whose leadership Bengal's influence came to be felt in northern India for quite some time.

Dharmapala was a devout Buddhist and a great patron of Buddhism. He is credited with the foundation of the Vikramasila monastery (at Patharghata, 6 miles to the north of Colgong and 24 miles to the east of Bhagalpur in Bihar), which was one of the most important seats of Buddhist learning in India from the 9th to the 12th centuries A.D. Somapura *Mahavihara* at Paharpur (in Naogaon district of Bangladesh) is another monumental architectural work of Dharmapala.

Somapura Mahavihar, included in the 'Heritage of Man' of UNESCO, is the largest Buddhist monastery in the Indian subcontinent (about 1000 feet square) and the second largest in the world. Its square plan with an open space in the middle, the centre of which is occupied by a central shrine built in gradually receding tiers having a crucified plan, set the architectural pattern for this type of monastic construction in south east Asian countries, especially Myanmar and Indonesia. The terracotta plaques decorating the wall surfaces at Paharpur are of exquisite quality and portray, besides religious subjects, scenes from the every day life of the people of Bengal. The Paharpur examples stand out as the finest specimen of this age-old art of Bengal.

Devapala, the son and successor of Dharmapala, maintained the aggressive policy of his father and during his reign the struggle for supremacy of northern India continued. He may have had some initial success, but ultimately the Gurjara Pratihara succeeded in establishing their empire over Kanauj and adjacent territories. The Pala empire was extended in other directions also, towards the south-west into Orissa and towards the north-east into Kamarupa.

The reigns of Dharmapala and Devapala formed the period of Pala ascendancy. These two rulers consolidated their empire in northern and western Bengal and in Bihar. Under them Bengal, for the first time in her history, came to be reckoned as a powerful force in north Indian politics. Bengal could hold its own against powerful rivals. There were all round conquests. But with them

ended the period of glory, and a period of stagnation followed which gradually led to decline and disintegration to be rejuvenated by Mahipala I.

The period of stagnation continued for more than hundred years covering reigns of five generations of kings. In this period the energy and vigour, which were so manifest during the reigns of Dharmapala and Devapala, were totally absent. Hardly was there any attempt at expansion; rather the Pala kings were not powerful enough to check incursions from outside or uprisings from inside. The Kambojas rose to an independent position in parts of western and northern Bengal and for a time the Pala empire was confined to parts of Bihar only.

The reign of Mahipala I (c. 995 – 1043 A.D.) brought back some vitality and gave a second lease of life to the Pala empire. He succeeded in bringing back the lost territories in northern and western Bengal and restored the position of his dynasty to a firmer footing. But during the reigns of his successors up to that of Ramapala, the fortune of the dynasty seems to have fallen to its lowest ebb. The repeated invasions of north Indian powers (Kalachuris and Chandellas) suggest the weakness of the Pala kings. But the weakness of the Pala rulers was clearly exposed during the reign of Mahipala II (c. 1075 – 1080 A.D.) when the revolt of the *Samantas* succeeded in northern Bengal under the independent rule of Divya, the Kaivarta chief. When the central authority becomes weak it is natural that the forces of disintegration should play their part. The success of Divya in north Bengal is the most glaring example of this tendency.

The vigour and energy of Ramapala (c. 1082 - 1124 A.D.) was the last significant flicker in the life of the Pala dynasty. He succeeded in restoring Pala authority in northern Bengal and in demonstrating the vigour in expansion programs. But his success was short lived and his successors were too weak to check the gradual decline. Vijayasena, possibly a feudatory ruler in the Pala empire, found opportunity to gather strength, and by the middle of the 12th century A.D. the Palas were ousted from their possessions in Bengal. Bengal saw the emergence of a new power, the Senas, under the leadership of Vijayasena, whose ancestors hailed from the Karnata country in southern India.

The long rule of the Pala dynasty, spreading over about four centuries, gave to Bengal the blessings of a stable government, which bore rich fruits in the arts of peace. The Palas were able to establish a sound administrative structure. Their land-based empire was basically agrarian in nature. Trade and commerce was not that important a factor in the Pala economy. Trading activities were possibly limited to within the region or at best beyond the borders to the adjacent territories. The decline of the port of Tamralipti after the 8th century A.D. deprived them of the outlet to a share of the sea-borne trade of Bengal.

The long Buddhist rule of the Palas generated an environment of religious toleration in Bengal and we notice an atmosphere of Hindu-Buddhist amity and co-existence. The Palas initiated a policy of religious toleration. Their liberal patronage of Hindu gods and goddesses as well as Brahmans, who were employed

in high state posts, clearly speaks of the sagacious policy of the rulers. This also resulted in narrowing the gaps between the two religions and one merging into the other gave rise to new forms and practices which culminated in the evolution of Tantric cults and practices among the Buddhists in Bengal. The socio-religious climate of the Pala period bred a spirit of toleration and mutual co-existence and this spirit had a far-reaching impact on the history of the land.

The Pala period is also significant for various achievements in the fields of arts. The Buddhist Vihara architecture attained maturity in the Somapura *Mahavihara* at Paharpur and this form influenced the subsequent structures in Southeast Asian countries. The terracotta art of Bengal reached its high water mark during this period. The Pala School of Sculptural Art came to be recognised as a distinct phase of Eastern Indian Art. The artistic genius of the Bengal sculptors found full expression in the Pala period. Though literary works of the period have not survived in large numbers, the *Ramacharitam*, the great poetic work of the north Bengali poet Sandhyakara Nandi, is testimony to the quality of composition in a rare form of verses, each having two meanings. The anthologies of poetry, compiled in the subsequent period, contain many verses composed by poets of the 10th and 11th centuries A.D. A few illustrated palm leaf manuscripts of Buddhist texts of the period depict the excellence in the art of painting. Considering all these achievements the Pala period can rightly be considered the most glorious period in the early history of Bengal.

Dynasties of Southeastern Bengal

Southeastern Bengal seems to have preserved an independent political entity for quite some time in the ancient period. From the break-up of the Gupta empire down to the coming of the Senas the deltaic part of Bengal was never assimilated in the political system of north and western Bengal, though from time to time there were attempts to do so.

As early as the first half of the sixth century A.D. southeastern Bengal formed an independent kingdom, the kingdom of Vanga, and the names of Gopachandra, Dharmaditya and Samacharadeva are preserved in six copperplates. It cannot be ascertained whether Sasanka's empire embraced southeastern Bengal. Scholars theorise about the probable existence of a Bhadra dynasty in this region in the second half of the 7th century A.D. When the Later Guptas captured power in Gauda (western Bengal) southeastern Bengal saw the emergence of the Khadga kings. We know about three generations of Khadga kings ruling Samatata (Comilla – Noakhali area) with their capital at Karmanta-vasaka (identified with Badkamta near Comilla). Two semi-independent feudatory chiefs, Lokanatha and Sridharana Rata, are known to have ruled in parts of Samatata in the 7th century A.D.

Southeastern Bengal emerged as a kingdom of considerable size and strength under the Deva dynasty in the 8th century A.D. with their capital at Devaparvata

(a city in the Mainamati-Lalmai area, the exact location of which is not yet settled). Four generations of rulers (Santideva, Viradeva, Anandadeva and Bhavadeva) ruled Samatata and they were contemporaries of the early Pala kings, who held sway over northern and western Bengal and Bihar. The Devas were Buddhists and under their patronage the Mainamati area rose into prominence as an important Buddhist cultural centre. The remains unearthed through archaeological excavations at Mainamati prove the existence of a few Buddhist Viharas (Buddhist religious and educational establishments) namely, Salban Vihara, Ananda Vihara and Bhoja Vihara built by the Deva rulers near their capital city of Devaparvata. The crucified plan of the central shrine, which is seen in a matured form at Paharpur, seems to have originated in the Mainamati area, where we see their earlier and smaller manifestations. Mainamati remains also contain terracotta plaques of high merit. The sculptural remains of Mainamati prove the development of this art in this region.

In the 9th century A.D., southeastern Bengal saw the emergence of the kingdom of Harikela, which may have embraced the area from Chittagong to Comilla. The Chandras followed the Harikela rulers and from the beginning of the 10th century A.D. five generations of Chandra rulers (Trailokychandra, Srichandra, Kalyanachandra, Ladachandra and Govindachandra) ruled for about 150 years (c. 900 – 1500 A.D.). Their empire embraced a large area (Vanga and Samatata) comprising the entire southern and southeastern Bangladesh and as far northeast as the Sylhet area. Their capital was at Vikramapur in present Munshiganj district, south of Dhaka.

The Chandras were quite powerful rulers and could match the power of the contemporary Palas of northern and western Bengal. Srichandra was the greatest ruler of the dynasty and under his vigorous rule the Chandra empire witnessed widespread expansion in the territories beyond the borders into Kamarupa (Assam).

In the last quarter of the 11th century A.D. the Varman dynasty, taking advantage of the Kaivarta rebellion in the Pala empire, established their independent rule in southeastern Bengal. Five generations of the Varmans (Jatavarman, Harivarman, Samalavarman and Bhojavarman) ruled for less than a century (c. 1080 – 1150 A.D.) before they were toppled by the Senas. The Varmans were Hindus and their capital was also at Vikramapur.

The rulers of southeastern Bengal commanded sea trade through the vast coastal area of Chittagong – Comilla region and this is attested to by the find of large number of silver coins in various places of their empire. The accounts of the Arab merchants and navigators, written between 9th and 11th century A.D., contain evidence of a flourishing sea trade in the coastal area of south-eastern Bengal, specially through the port which the Arabs called 'Samandar', identified with the area near the present Chittagong port. The rulers of southeastern Bengal were able to earn the necessary bullion for the issue of

silver coins. We also have evidence of boat building industries in the records of the period. The picture of a flourishing sea-trade emerges very clearly and the resultant economic affluence of the area is beyond any doubt.

The Sena Dynasty

Towards the end of the 12th century A.D. Vijayasena founded the Sena empire. His forefathers hailed from the Karnata country of the Deccan, but he emerged in the politics of Bengal as a feudatory ruler in West Bengal during the rule of the Pala emperor Ramapala. During the period of decline of the Palas after Ramapala, Vijayasena rose into prominence and gradually grabbed power. He defeated the Varmans in southeastern Bengal and then ousted the Palas from northern and western Bengal. He also attempted to expand his empire in northern Bihar and adjacent territories. The Palas lingered on for some time in southern Bihar until the Muslim occupation of the area in the beginning of the 13th century A.D.

The Senas held sway over Bengal for more than a century (c.1097 - 1223 A.D.) in which five generations of kings (Vijayasena, Vallalasena, Laksmanasena, Visvarupasena and Kesavasena) ruled. But it must be noted that the invasion of Muhammad Bakhtiyar Khalji put an end to Sena rule in parts of western and northern Bengal (in 1204 A.D.) and Laksmanasena had to fall back on his possessions in southeastern Bengal where, after him, his two sons ruled for some time. It should also be noted that Vijayasena, after having ousted the Varmans and the Palas, succeeded in bringing the whole of Bengal under one unified rule which continued up to 1204 A.D. So in a sense, it can be said that it was only under the Senas that the whole of Bengal came under a single rule. The separate political entity of southeastern Bengal in the preceding four centuries must have had deep-rooted socio-cultural consequences in the history of Bengal. Vikramapura, which was the capital of the Chandras and the Varmans, continued to be the capital of the Senas as well.

The first three kings of the dynasty – Vijayasena (c.1097 - 1160 A.D.), Vallalasena (c.1160 - 1178 A.D.) and Laksmanasena (c.1178 - 1206 A.D.) – were important figures of the dynasty. The last two held on to power in a very limited empire in southeastern Bengal. The Sena rulers were Hindus and their rule is considered to be a period of revival of Hinduism in Bengal. Vallalasena is known to have attempted the establishment of orthodox Hindu social order with caste rigidity. It was an attempt to bring back Hindu orthodoxy in a society that had long lived in a social milieu of religious toleration and Hindu-Buddhist amity. The decline of Buddhism in Bengal may be ascribed to this change in social order. It is not unlikely that Buddhism received a rude shock from this revival of orthodox Hinduism by the Senas and it is rightly said that “it was not Islam which overcame Buddhism, but a more jealous rival of nearer origin” and it is

clear that "Buddhism had already been severely crippled before the Muslims reached Bengal ". This scenario of Hindu-Buddhist enmity in Bengal and the attempt at bringing back Hindu orthodoxy in the Sena period may be said to have had a far-reaching impact on the history of Bengal. The scenario may have indirectly helped the cause of Islam in Bengal.

The Sena period is significant from another point of view. The period saw the development of Sanskrit literature in Bengal. It was partly the direct patronage of the Sena Kings and partly to the environment created by them; that literary activities in Sanskrit are distinctly visible in this period. By far the most important contribution of Bengal to the poetic literature in Sanskrit is the *Gitagovinda* of Jayadeva, who was one of the ornaments of the court of Laksmanasena. Other luminaries of his court were poets *Dhoyi* (author of *Pavanaduta*), Umapatidhara, Govardhana (author of *Arya-Sapta-Sati*) and Sarana, and these five may be regarded as the five *ratnas* (jewels) of the court of Laksmanasena.

One anthology (*Sadukti Karnamrita*) compiled by Sridharadasa during this period stands out as a treasure house of poetical works of the period as also of earlier periods. It contains 2370 poems composed by 485 poets whose dates range from the 10th to 12th century A.D. Bhavadeva Bhatta and Jimutavahana, two great writers of Dharmasastra, belong to this period. Vallalasena and Laksmanasena were royal authors of no mean merit. Halayudha's *Brahmanasaruvasva* was also written in this period. Mention of other works and authors would only make this list longer. It is really noteworthy that 12th century Bengal under the Senas witnessed unprecedented flourishing of literary activities in Sanskrit.

Another arena of the artistic achievements of the period was in the field of sculptural art. The Bengal school of sculptural art reached its high water mark in the Sena period and in this phase its regional character marked by individualistic traits became manifest.

Suggested Readings:

1. R.C. Majumdar (ed.) *History of Bengal*, D.U. Publication, 1943.
2. R.C. Majumdar; *History of Ancient Bengal*, Calcutta, 1972.
3. A.M. Chowdhury; *Dynastic History of Bengal*, Dhaka, 1967.